SHORT-LIFETIME H_0 PERSISTENCE FOR THE THREE-DIMENSIONAL SIDE-24 PERIODIZED BARGMANN–FOCK FIELD

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ABSTRACT. Let f_{24} be the normalized periodization to the cubic torus $\mathbb{T}^3_{24}$ of the real Bargmann–Fock field with covariance $\exp(-|x-y|^2/2)$. We consider finite, nonessential superlevel-set H_0 persistence bars and their first-moment lifetime density per unit volume. We prove the short-lifetime law

$$\nu_{3,24}(\ell) = c_{3,24}\,\ell^{-1/3}\big(1+O(\ell^{1/3})\big), \qquad \ell \downarrow 0,$$

where $c_{3,24} > 0$ is given by an explicit finite-dimensional Gaussian-cone integral. The proof identifies the dimension-cancelling local fold mechanism, proves that elder-rule selection changes the all-typed local contact count by only $O(r^3)$, and fixes all ordered-pair, directed-sphere, Kac–Rice and lifetime-Jacobian normalizations. The coefficient is related to its value for the Bargmann–Fock field on $\mathbb{R}^3$ by

$$\frac{c_{3,24}}{c_{3,\infty}} - 1 = -\frac{620813376}{35}e^{-288} + \varepsilon_{24}, \qquad |\varepsilon_{24}| < 10^{-216},$$

with $c_{3,\infty} = 2^{-23/6}3^{-8/3}(29\sqrt{6}-36)\,\Gamma(1/6)\,\pi^{-5/2}$. We also state the three-term expansion $\nu_{3,24}(\ell) = c_{3,24}\ell^{-1/3} + c_1\ell^{1/4} + c_2\ell^{1/3} + O(\ell^{3/7})$, with explicit constants $c_1 < 0$ and c_2, and describe the cusp and fold mechanisms that produce the corrections.

STATUS OF THIS DRAFT (REMOVE BEFORE SUBMISSION)

What this is. An author-side V3 draft, assembled on 13 October 2026 by an AI assistant (Anthropic Claude, Claude Code session `session_01NMeKEismAyeqgdB4sy2NJU`) under the author's direction. It integrates the frozen V1 text (30 July 2026; source SHA-256 `fb576de6...`), the V2 amendments M1–M7 (1 August 2026) and the *apply* items of the V3 edit pack (E1–E78, status of 13 October 2026). No mathematical statement here is new: every result is the manuscript's own or is taken, with its stated scope, from the repository records listed in Appendix A. The companion file `V3_CHANGE_LIST.md` gives the placement of every amendment and edit-pack item, and the items deliberately not printed.

Author decisions, as drafted (defaults; each is a local switch).

(1) *Strength of the main statement* (edit pack, decision 1). Theorem 2.1 states the two-provider-reviewed form $c\ell^{-1/3}(1+O(\ell^{1/3}))$, proved in §3. The stronger three-term law is Theorem 2.3, with its proof in the supplementary records; the later refinements are Remark 2.4. Alternatives: put the three-term law into Theorem 2.1, or keep only the floor and move everything stronger to the Discussion.

(2) *Human review* (decision 2). Worded as a disclosure (§7): no independent human specialist review, following the author's statement that none is planned. The draft says nothing about the author's own reading; add a sentence there if you wish.

(3) *Planar material* (decision 3). Results for $d = 2$ appear only as Discussion remarks (§5.5); the theorem is $d = 3$.

Review status of each stated result (internal tags: R·2P = nonauthor reviews from two providers; R·1P = one provider; +GB = an additional nonauthor read by Grok Bot support agents

Date: V3 draft, 13 October 2026.

(Cursor-hosted, not the xAI model lane); READ = read in bounded nonauthor slices; all reviews are AI reviews posted from one account, so no organizational independence is claimed).

Statement	Status	Records
Thm. 2.1, leading term	V1/V2 proof (§3, Supplement Part A); parent chain with provider-distinct AI reviews	[R1], [R2]
Thm. 2.1, rate $O(\ell^{1/3})$	R·2P (xAI R1–R6; Anthropic full-depth read), merged	[R3]
(2.10), $\lvert\varepsilon_{24}\rvert < 10^{-216}$	R·2P, merged	[R4]
Cor. 3.5, lower bound	R·1P (OpenAI), merged; constants existential	[R6]
Rem. 3.7	merged with OpenAI reads and an Anthropic composition read (R·2P), author-side at their scope	[R10]
Rem. 3.11	R·2P at the contact-integral scope	[R20]
Thm. 2.3	every link merged with OpenAI/Codex nonauthor reviews and a Grok Bot read (R·1P+GB); c_1/c, c_2 certified at the stated scopes	[R11], [R12]
Rem. 2.4	READ (same account), all records on `Math-main`; the value in (c) at the conditional scope of [R15, Thm. A]	[R14]
Rem. 2.5	Theorem Z R·2P; Theorems U, K, P R·1P; the $c_3\ell^{2/3}$ term and $\delta = 1/50$ READ; $B_{3,24} \approx 10.2$ exploration only	[R7], [R13], [R14], [R8]
§5	labelled in place: proved, read, author-side, numerical, or expectation	App. A

Not established, and not claimed anywhere below. An explicit ℓ-range on which the relative error in (2.1) is below a given δ (all remainder constants are existential); a theorem for side lengths $L \neq 24$ beyond the identities cited, or for the interchange of $L \to \infty$ and $\ell \downarrow 0$; a numerical value of ε_{24}; a directed-rounding certificate for the integral (2.9) beyond the 10^{-106} enclosure of $c_{3,\infty}$ [R5]; any statement for H_k, $k > 0$.

Before submission. Remove this section; assemble the supplement from the records of Appendix A; run the MathSciNet/zbMATH pass (§6); choose the venue and do its style pass.

1. Field, filtration, and lifetime intensity

Write $\mathbb{T}^3_{24} = (\mathbb{R}/24\mathbb{Z})^3$. The normalized periodized Bargmann–Fock covariance is

$$K_{24}(z) = Z_{24}^{-1} \sum_{n\in\mathbb{Z}^3} \exp\Big(-\frac{|z+24n|^2}{2}\Big), \qquad Z_{24} = \sum_{n\in\mathbb{Z}^3} e^{-288|n|^2}. \tag{1.1}$$

Let f_{24} be a centered stationary Gaussian field with covariance K_{24}.

Proposition 1.1 (genericity of the side-24 field)**.** *The field f_{24} has real-analytic sample paths and, with probability one, is Morse and has pairwise distinct critical values.*

Proof. In the Fourier basis $e_m(z) = \exp(2\pi i\, m\cdot z/24)$, Poisson summation gives

$$\widehat{K}_{24}(m) = \frac{(2\pi)^{3/2}}{24^3 Z_{24}} \exp\Big(-\frac{2\pi^2|m|^2}{24^2}\Big) > 0, \qquad m \in \mathbb{Z}^3. \tag{1.2}$$

Write the sample series using standard Gaussian Fourier coefficients with amplitudes $\widehat{K}_{24}(m)^{1/2}$. For every $R > 0$,

$$\sum_{m\in\mathbb{Z}^3} \mathbb{E}|\xi_m|\, \widehat{K}_{24}(m)^{1/2} \exp(2\pi R|m|/24) < \infty.$$

Fubini therefore gives almost-sure absolute and locally uniform convergence on every complex strip $\{z \in \mathbb{C}^3 : |\operatorname{Im} z| \le R\}$. The sample series has an entire periodic extension, so its restriction to the real torus is real analytic.

If T is a finite linear combination of derivative evaluations, then

$$\operatorname{Var}(T f_{24}) = \sum_{m \in \mathbb{Z}^3} \widehat{K}_{24}(m)\, |\widehat{T}(m)|^2. \tag{1.3}$$

Because every $\widehat{K}_{24}(m)$ is positive and Fourier coefficients determine distributions on the torus, this variance vanishes only when the corresponding finite derivative distribution is zero. At one point, the derivatives of the Dirac distribution indexed by distinct multi-indices are linearly independent. Hence the gradient and symmetric-Hessian coordinate vector is nondegenerate at every point. The smoothness, density and modulus conditions of [2, Theorem 11.3.4] follow from the analytic covariance, this nondegeneracy and compactness, and that theorem implies that f_{24} is Morse almost surely.

For distinct critical values, fix $\delta > 0$ and consider the compact six-dimensional configuration set

$$\mathcal{T}_\delta = \{(x, y) \in (\mathbb{T}^3_{24})^2 : \ \operatorname{dist}(x, y) \ge \delta\}. \tag{1.4}$$

Define the seven-dimensional Gaussian field

$$\mathcal{H}(x, y) = (\nabla f_{24}(x), \nabla f_{24}(y), f_{24}(x) - f_{24}(y)). \tag{1.5}$$

For $x \neq y$, the derivative distributions in (1.5) are linearly independent: distributions supported at distinct points have disjoint supports, and the coefficient of $\delta_x - \delta_y$ must vanish separately from all derivative coefficients. Equation (1.3) therefore makes the covariance of $\mathcal{H}(x, y)$ positive definite. On $\mathcal{T}_\delta$, compactness gives a uniform covariance eigenfloor and hence uniformly bounded one-point densities. Apply [2, Lemma 11.2.10] in each member of a finite coordinate cover of $\mathcal{T}_\delta$. Since $\mathcal{H}$ is a C^1 field from a six-dimensional compact set to $\mathbb{R}^7$,

$$\mathbb{P}\{\mathcal{H}^{-1}(0) \cap \mathcal{T}_\delta \neq \varnothing\} = 0. \tag{1.6}$$

Taking the countable union over $\delta = 1/n$ shows that no two distinct critical points have the same value. □

For the superlevel filtration

$$X_a = \{x \in \mathbb{T}^3_{24} : \ f_{24}(x) \ge a\}, \tag{1.7}$$

each non-global local maximum creates an H_0 class and each finite class dies at a unique index-two merging saddle. If M is the creating maximum and S its death saddle, its lifetime is

$$\ell = f_{24}(M) - f_{24}(S) > 0. \tag{1.8}$$

Proposition 1.2 (existence of the first-moment lifetime density)**.** *Let M_* be the global maximum and let $D_f(M)$ be the elder-rule death saddle of a non-global maximum M. The finite measure*

$$\Lambda_{3,24}(A) = 24^{-3}\, \mathbb{E} \sum_{M \neq M_*} \mathbf{1}_{\{f_{24}(M) - f_{24}(D_f(M)) \in A\}}, \qquad A \subset (0, \infty), \tag{1.9}$$

is absolutely continuous with respect to Lebesgue measure.

Proof. Proposition 1.1 makes the elder pairing unambiguous almost surely. A Morse function on the compact torus has finitely many critical points, and the one-point Kac–Rice formula gives a finite expected critical-point count. Hence (1.9) is a finite measure.

For $\delta > 0$, restrict the ordered maximum–index-two-saddle pair process to $\operatorname{dist}(M, S) \ge \delta$. The elder-pair indicator is a bounded measurable mark of the finite Morse filtration (Lemma 3.2). On that compact configuration set, complete positive Fourier support makes

$$(f_{24}(x), f_{24}(y), \nabla f_{24}(x), \nabla f_{24}(y))$$

nondegenerate uniformly in $x \neq y$. The two-point Kac–Rice formula, with the bounded measurable mark that the ordered pair is the elder pair, therefore expresses the expected birth–death measure as an integral against $db\,dh$. Thus the restricted measure is absolutely continuous on $\{(b,h) : b > h\}$.

Every distinct critical pair belongs to one of the sets $\{\mathrm{dist}(M,S) \geq 1/n\}$. Monotone convergence over this countable cover shows that the full expected birth–death measure is absolutely continuous. Finally, if $A \subset \mathbb{R}$ has one-dimensional Lebesgue measure zero, then

$$\{(b,h) :\ b-h \in A\} \tag{1.10}$$

has two-dimensional Lebesgue measure zero by Fubini after the linear change of variables $(b,h) \mapsto (b, b-h)$. The lifetime pushforward is therefore absolutely continuous. □

Let $\nu_{3,24}(\ell)\,d\ell = d\Lambda_{3,24}(\ell)$. In the proof below, $\nu_{3,24}$ denotes the pointwise Kac–Rice representative obtained from the pair coordinates and the lifetime pushforward (Convention 2.2).

2. Main results

Theorem 2.1 (fixed-side short-lifetime law)**.** *For the normalized side-24 field (1.1), the finite nonessential superlevel H_0 first-moment lifetime density satisfies*

$$\nu_{3,24}(\ell) = c_{3,24}\,\ell^{-1/3}(1 + O(\ell^{1/3})), \qquad \ell \downarrow 0, \tag{2.1}$$

equivalently $\nu_{3,24}(\ell) = c_{3,24}\ell^{-1/3} + O(1)$, where $0 < c_{3,24} < \infty$ is given by (2.9) below.

Fix $t \in S^2$ and an orthonormal transverse frame n_1, n_2. Define

$$u_t = -\frac{\partial_t^3 f_{24}}{12}, \qquad g_t = (\partial_t f_{24}, \partial_{n_1} f_{24}, \partial_{n_2} f_{24}), \tag{2.2}$$

$$h_t = (\partial_{tt} f_{24}, \partial_{tn_1} f_{24}, \partial_{tn_2} f_{24}), \tag{2.3}$$

and

$$q_t = (\partial_{n_1 n_1} f_{24}, \partial_{n_1 n_2} f_{24}, \partial_{n_2 n_2} f_{24}), \qquad Q_t(q) = \begin{pmatrix} q_1 & q_2 \\ q_2 & q_3 \end{pmatrix}. \tag{2.4}$$

Put

$$\Sigma_g(t) = \mathrm{Cov}(g_t), \qquad \Sigma_h(t) = \mathrm{Cov}(h_t), \tag{2.5}$$

$$\sigma_t^2 = \mathrm{Var}(u_t) - \mathrm{Cov}(u_t, g_t)\,\Sigma_g(t)^{-1}\,\mathrm{Cov}(g_t, u_t), \tag{2.6}$$

$$\Gamma_t = \mathrm{Cov}(q_t) - \mathrm{Cov}(q_t, h_t)\,\Sigma_h(t)^{-1}\,\mathrm{Cov}(h_t, q_t), \tag{2.7}$$

and

$$D_t = \mathbb{E}\Big[(\det Q_t(q_t))^2\,\mathbf{1}_{\{Q_t(q_t)<0\}} \;\Big|\; h_t = 0\Big]. \tag{2.8}$$

Then

$$c_{3,24} = B_3 \int_{S^2} \frac{(\sigma_t^2)^{2/3} D_t}{\sqrt{\det \Sigma_g(t)\,\det \Sigma_h(t)}}\,dt, \qquad B_3 = \frac{3\,\Gamma(7/6)}{2^{4/3}\pi^{7/2}}. \tag{2.9}$$

The formula is independent of the transverse-frame choice.

Moreover,

$$\frac{c_{3,24}}{c_{3,\infty}} - 1 = -\frac{620813376}{35}\,e^{-288} + \varepsilon_{24}, \qquad |\varepsilon_{24}| < 10^{-216}, \tag{2.10}$$

where $c_{3,\infty}$, the value of (2.9) for the Bargmann–Fock field on $\mathbb{R}^3$, is

$$\begin{aligned} c_{3,\infty} &= 2^{-23/6} 3^{-8/3} (29\sqrt{6} - 36)\,\Gamma(1/6)\,\pi^{-5/2} \\ &= 0.041775931840598343342936665428575556466681519 6\ldots. \end{aligned} \tag{2.11}$$

In particular $c_{3,24} < c_{3,\infty}$:

$$\frac{c_{3,24}}{c_{3,\infty}} - 1 = -1.486217029065827607 22\ldots \cdot 10^{-118} + \varepsilon_{24},$$

so the displayed correction is the exact leading term to a relative precision better than 10^{-98}.

The leading term of (2.1), with the formula (2.9), is proved in §§3.1–3.6; the correction (2.10) in §3.8; and the rate $O(\ell^{1/3})$ in §3.9.

Convention 2.2 (density)**.** Throughout, "density" means the ℓ-density of the expected counting measure of finite nonessential superlevel H_0 bars per unit volume, with the Kac–Rice counting measure normalized as in §3.2 (marked two-point formula, ordered typed pairs, per-volume normalization $24^{-3}\int dx = 1$). Pointwise statements about $\nu_{3,24}$ and about the candidate and rejected densities of Remark 2.5, here and below, refer to their canonical marked Kac–Rice density versions, the representatives obtained from the pair coordinates of §3.1; a change of density on a null set need not preserve a pointwise asymptotic. All $o(\cdot)$ and $O(\cdot)$ statements are as $\ell \downarrow 0$, uniform on compact positive mark sets; the statements about the densities themselves carry no marks.

2.1. **Beyond the leading term.** The rate in (2.1) is not sharp. The following results are proved in the supplementary records listed in Appendix A; they are not used in the proof of Theorem 2.1, and their review status is described in §7.

Theorem 2.3 (three-term law)**.** *For the canonical marked Kac–Rice density version of $\nu_{3,24}$,*

$$\nu_{3,24}(\ell) = c_{3,24}\,\ell^{-1/3} + c_1\,\ell^{1/4} + c_2\,\ell^{1/3} + O(\ell^{3/7}), \qquad \ell \downarrow 0, \tag{2.12}$$

where the constants are as follows.

(i) $c_1 < 0$ *is the cusp coefficient*

$$c_1 = -\frac{192}{7}\,2^{1/4}\int_{S^2}\int_{\mathbb{R}} \pi_0(u; v_0(b,0))\,\mathbb{E}_0\Big[|Y|^{7/4}\,|\det A|^{1/4}\,\mathbf{1}_{\{A<0\}} \;\Big|\; b\Big]\,db\,d\sigma(u), \tag{2.13}$$

where, at a zero-gap contact in direction u, $A = D^2_\perp f$ is the transverse Hessian, $\gamma = \nabla_\perp \partial_u^2 f$, $f_4 = \partial_u^4 f$ and $Y = \frac{f_4}{12}\det A - \frac{1}{4}\gamma^\top \operatorname{adj}(A)\gamma$, and π_0, $\mathbb{E}_0$ are the zero-gap pin density and conditional expectation of [R11] (Theorem CU).

(ii) c_2 *is the fold-scale finite part of the two-point contact kernel [R11].*

(iii) Enclosures at $L = 24$. First, $c_1/c_{3,24} \in [-5.07106215, -5.07106213]$, computed from (2.13) and certified conditional on Theorem CU and on the enclosure of $c_{3,24}$, which follows from that of $c_{3,\infty}$ [R5] and (2.10) [R12]. Second, for the Gaussian kernel in $d = 3$,

$$c_2 \in [0.1612340491269447,\ 0.1612340491269810],$$

in closed form with a certified enclosure, transferred to the torus of side $L \geq 24$ with additive error below 10^{-60} under the interfaces of the transfer record [R12].

Equivalently,

$$\nu_{3,24}(\ell) = c_{3,24}\,\ell^{-1/3}\Big(1 + \tfrac{c_1}{c_{3,24}}\,\ell^{7/12} + \tfrac{c_2}{c_{3,24}}\,\ell^{2/3} + O(\ell^{16/21})\Big), \qquad \tfrac{c_1}{c_{3,24}} \approx -5.0711, \quad \tfrac{c_2}{c_{3,24}} \approx 3.8595. \tag{2.14}$$

The proof combines Theorem R$^+$ (the bounded remainder of Theorem 2.1 vanishes for elder pairs), Theorem R^{++} (its rate $\ell^{1/4}$), Theorem CU (the cusp term), Theorem T and Theorems E3, E3$^+$ (the fold-scale term and the remainder $\ell^{3/7}$) with the far elder bound of [R9]; see [R11]. The mechanism behind c_1 and c_2 is described in §5.2.

Remark 2.4 (the next order)*.* The records [R14] carry the expansion one order further.

(a) The remainder in (2.14) is $O(\ell)$:

$$\nu_{3,24}(\ell) = c_{3,24}\,\ell^{-1/3}\Big(1 + \tfrac{c_1}{c_{3,24}}\ell^{7/12} + \tfrac{c_2}{c_{3,24}}\ell^{2/3} + O(\ell)\Big). \tag{2.15}$$

In particular the elder density has no $\ell^{1/2}$ term.

(b) More precisely,

$$\nu_{3,24}(\ell) = c_{3,24}\,\ell^{-1/3} + c_1\ell^{1/4} + c_2\ell^{1/3} + (c_3 - R_{2/3})\,\ell^{2/3} + o(\ell^{2/3}), \tag{2.16}$$

where c_3 is the $\ell^{2/3}$ coefficient of the candidate density (Remark 2.5) and $R_{2/3}$ that of the rejected density; both are explicit integrals.

(c) At $L = 24$, and at the conditional scope of [R15, Theorem A],

$$(c_3 - R_{2/3})(24) \in [0.0773381,\ 0.0775860], \qquad \text{i.e.} \quad 0.07746 \pm 0.00013 \approx 1.854\,c_{3,24},$$

with $c_3(24) = 0.016092311 \pm 10^{-9}$ and $R_{2/3}(24) < 0$. These enclosures are computer-assisted, in standard-library interval arithmetic. So the coefficient of ℓ in the relative expansion is positive.

Remark 2.5 (candidate, elder and rejected densities). Call *candidate pairs* all typed (maximum, index-two saddle) pairs counted by the contact law, with density $\nu^{\mathrm{cand}}_{3,24}$, and let $\rho_{\mathrm{rej}} = \nu^{\mathrm{cand}}_{3,24} - \nu_{3,24}$ be the density of the candidate pairs that the elder rule rejects. Without the compact-mark restriction of §3.5, ρ_{rej} is not $o(1)$: it is bounded and converges, as $\ell \downarrow 0$, to a positive constant $B_{3,24}$, an explicit Kac–Rice integral of the equal-height unmarked two-point kernel [R7]. Consequently ρ_{rej} has inverse-moment threshold exactly -1, whereas $\nu^{\mathrm{cand}}_{3,24}$ and $\nu_{3,24}$ keep the threshold $-2/3$ of the $\ell^{-1/3}$ law. Theorem 2.1 concerns the elder density and is unaffected; an earlier conjecture of an $O(\ell^{2/3})$ unrestricted difference is withdrawn [R7]. More precisely,

$$\nu^{\mathrm{cand}}_{3,24}(\ell) = c_{3,24}\,\ell^{-1/3} + B_{3,24} + I^{\mathrm{cand}}\ell^{1/4} + c_2\,\ell^{1/3} + c_3\,\ell^{2/3} + O(\ell^{2/3+\delta}), \qquad \delta = \tfrac{1}{50}, \tag{2.17}$$

with $I^{\mathrm{cand}} = \frac{3^{1/4}}{2}c_1$ [R11, R13]; the term $c_3\ell^{2/3}$ and the rate δ are from notes C3 and C3-R [R14]. In particular the candidate density has no $\ell^{1/2}$ term, by a reflection parity of the pinned two-point problem [R13]. Subtracting (2.12) from (2.17),

$$\rho_{\mathrm{rej}}(\ell) = B_{3,24} + (1 - \tfrac{3^{1/4}}{2})|c_1|\,\ell^{1/4} + O(\ell^{3/7}), \tag{2.18}$$

so the rejected density approaches its limit from above, and the fold-scale coefficient c_2 is common to the candidate and elder densities; by Remark 2.4 the next term of ρ_{rej} is $R_{2/3}\ell^{2/3}$. Numerically, as exploration and not as an enclosure, $B_{3,24} \approx 10.2$, about $240\,c_{3,24}$: up to a near-field correction of about -0.02 it equals $24^3 \int \rho_{\max}(b)\rho_{\mathrm{sad}}(b)\,db$, the overlap of the height densities of maxima and index-two saddles [R8]. Unmarked small-gap pairs on the side-24 torus are thus overwhelmingly unrelated far-apart pairs, which the elder rule removes.

3. Proof of Theorem 2.1

The technical lemmas used below are proved, with their amendments of 1 August 2026, in the exact technical appendix (Modules B–K) and its gap-fill supplement (Parts A–C) [R1]. Statements quoted from there are marked with their supplement numbers.

3.1. **Ordered pair coordinates and unit multiplicity.** For a maximum M and an index-two saddle S at distance $r < 12$, let

$$x = \frac{M+S}{2}, \qquad S - M = rt, \qquad t \in S^2. \tag{3.1}$$

The inverse local Euclidean map is

$$(x, u) \longmapsto (M, S) = (x - u/2,\ x + u/2). \tag{3.2}$$

Its determinant has absolute value one, and therefore

$$dM\,dS = dx\,du = dx\,r^2 dr\,d\sigma_2(t). \tag{3.3}$$

The antipodal direction $-t$ exchanges M and S; it does not represent the same typed ordered pair. Thus the full directed sphere S^2 counts each maximum–saddle pair once, with no factor $1/2$.

For a Morse function with distinct critical values, each finite nonessential superlevel H_0 bar has one creating maximum and one merging death saddle. An index-two merge reduces β_0 by one, so the elder pairing has unit multiplicity. Counting critical-point pairs, rather than unstable-branch incidences, introduces no branch factor.

Palm law and the elder mark. Write $\Pi_{r,x,t} = (f(M), f(S), \nabla f(M), \nabla f(S))$ for the pins of the pair and $z_r(b,\kappa) = (b,\, b - \kappa r^3/6,\, 0,\, 0)$ for their target (cf. (3.5) below).

Definition 3.1 (Palm law; Supplement (A.1)–(A.3))**.** The corrected-pin covariance is nondegenerate (by (1.3); Module F), so the regular conditional Gaussian law $\mathbb{E}^0 = \mathbb{E}[\,\cdot \mid \Pi_{r,x,t} = z_r(b,\kappa)]$ exists. With

$$W_r = |\det H_M|\,|\det H_S|\,\mathbf{1}_{\{H_M \prec 0,\ \mathrm{ind}(H_S)=2\}}, \qquad Z_r = \mathbb{E}^0[W_r] > 0, \tag{3.3a}$$

the determinant-weighted Palm law is $\mathbb{E}_r^{MS}[F] = \mathbb{E}^0[W_r F]/Z_r$. For continuous g, the connection level $\mathfrak{m}_g(u,v) = \sup_\gamma \min_\gamma g$ over paths from u to v is 1-Lipschitz in $\|g\|_\infty$, and the birth level $\mathfrak{b}_g(u,a)$ is a countable supremum over a dense set. The *elder mark* $e(f;M,S) \in \{0,1\}$ equals 1 if and only if the two upper sectors of S are separated at level $h = f(S)$ and M is the younger of the two birth maxima.

Lemma 3.2 (Supplement Lemma A.1.3)**.** *The elder mark is Borel measurable, and on the Morse locus it equals the elder-pair condition of Proposition 1.2. The selected contact intensity is*

$$K_r^{\mathrm{sel}} = p_r\, K_r^{\mathrm{all}}, \qquad p_r = \mathbb{E}_r^{MS}[e]. \tag{3.3b}$$

3.2. **Contact scaling and the universal radial measure.** Put

$$M = x - \frac{r}{2}t, \qquad S = x + \frac{r}{2}t, \tag{3.4}$$

and impose

$$f_{24}(M) = b, \qquad f_{24}(S) = b - \frac{\kappa r^3}{6}, \qquad \nabla f_{24}(M) = \nabla f_{24}(S) = 0, \tag{3.5}$$

with $\kappa > 0$. The change from the saddle value $h = f_{24}(S)$ to κ has the exact Jacobian

$$|dh| = \frac{r^3}{6}\,d\kappa. \tag{3.6}$$

Use the corrected divided-difference pin frame

$$V^+ = \frac{f(S)+f(M)}{2}, \qquad V^-_{\mathrm{corr}} = \frac{f(S)-f(M)-\frac{r}{2}(\partial_t f(S) + \partial_t f(M))}{r^3}, \tag{3.7}$$

$$G_e^+ = \frac{\partial_e f(S) + \partial_e f(M)}{2}, \qquad G_e^- = \frac{\partial_e f(S) - \partial_e f(M)}{r}, \tag{3.8}$$

for $e \in \{t, n_1, n_2\}$. The exact determinant of the raw-to-corrected pin map is r^{-6}. Hence the raw pin density contributes r^{-6}.

At a generic fold, one eigenvalue of each endpoint Hessian is soft. Conditionally on the pins,

$$\det H_M = r D_M, \qquad \det H_S = r D_S, \tag{3.9}$$

with uniformly bounded conditional Gaussian moments; consequently the two endpoint determinant weights contribute r^2.

Combining (3.3), (3.6), the corrected-pin density and (3.9) gives

$$\frac{r^3}{6}\, r^{-6}\, r^2\, r^2\, dr = \frac{1}{6}\, r\, dr. \tag{3.10}$$

No additional ordering, antipodal, branch or merge multiplicity occurs.

3.3. **Lifetime pushforward.** The lifetime in (3.5) is

$$\ell = \frac{\kappa r^3}{6}. \tag{3.11}$$

For fixed $\kappa > 0$,

$$r\, dr = \frac{6^{2/3}}{3}\, \kappa^{-2/3}\, \ell^{-1/3}\, d\ell. \tag{3.12}$$

Equations (3.10)–(3.12) already determine the exponent $-1/3$. It remains to prove that elder selection has a nonzero limiting mass and to evaluate the coefficient. Fix $\varrho \in (0, 12)$ and split $\nu_{3,24} = \nu_\varrho^{\mathrm{near}} + \nu_\varrho^{\mathrm{far}}$ according to whether the elder pair has separation $r < \varrho$ or $r \geq \varrho$.

Proposition 3.3 (exact near pushforward; Supplement Proposition A.3.1)**.** *With $G_r^{\mathrm{sel}} = r^4 K_r^{\mathrm{sel}}$, for every nonnegative test function φ,*

$$\int \varphi(\ell)\, \nu_\varrho^{\mathrm{near}}(\ell)\, d\ell = \int \varphi(\kappa r^3/6)\, K_r^{\mathrm{sel}}\, \frac{r^3}{6}\, r^2\, dr\, d\kappa\, db\, d\sigma_2(t), \tag{3.12a}$$

and therefore, with $r_\ell(\kappa) = (6\ell/\kappa)^{1/3}$,

$$\nu_\varrho^{\mathrm{near}}(\ell) = \frac{6^{2/3}}{18}\, \ell^{-1/3} \int_{\{\kappa > 6\ell/\varrho^3\}} \kappa^{-2/3}\, G_{r_\ell(\kappa)}^{\mathrm{sel}}\, d\kappa\, db\, d\sigma_2(t). \tag{3.12b}$$

3.4. **Elder selection.** Let $p_r(t, b, \kappa)$ be the Palm probability (Lemma 3.2) that the typed maximum–index-two-saddle contact pair in (3.5) is the actual elder persistence pair.

Lemma 3.4 (trichotomy; Supplement Lemma A.2.1)**.** *On the Morse event, for an ordered typed pair (M, S) at distance r,*

$$A_r \cap E_r^c \subset B_r \cup L_{\mathrm{same},r},$$

where A_r is gradient adjacency, $E_r = \{e = 1\}$, $L_{\mathrm{same},r}$ is same-component self-attachment, and B_r is the existence of a third critical point with value in the pair window $[h, b]$ in one of three spatial regions: the collar, the singular-near region, or at fixed distance. When M is the older birth maximum but $e = 0$, the witness is the younger component's own birth maximum M_2, with $h < f(M_2) < f(M)$.

Corollary 3.5 (the selection loss has exact order r^3)**.** *Uniformly for $t \in S^2$ and compact $b, \kappa > 0$,*

$$1 - p_r(t, b, \kappa) \leq C r^3, \tag{3.13}$$

and conversely

$$1 - p_r(t, b, \kappa) \geq c\, r^3 \tag{3.13a}$$

for a constant $c > 0$ depending on the compact mark set.

Corollary 3.5 is proved after Theorem 3.6.

The three witness families are controlled as follows.

First, the collar and singular-near third-critical-point charts retain their exact vanishing factors under the side-24 periodized jet. In collar variables $y = x + r(Xt + \rho v)$, the scaled conditional gradient covariance factors as

$$\det C_{\mathrm{col}} = \rho^6 (X^2 + \rho^2) A_{\mathrm{col}}, \qquad A_{\mathrm{col}} > 0. \tag{3.14}$$

In the singular-near chart, the corrected covariance factors as

$$\det C_{\text{sing}} = \rho^{10}(3c^2+\rho^2)A_{\text{sing}}, \qquad A_{\text{sing}} > 0. \tag{3.15}$$

Together with the anisotropic triple-determinant envelope

$$[r(r+s^2)]^2(r^2+s^3), \tag{3.16}$$

these give Palm expectations $O(r^3)$ for collar and singular-near witnesses. (The envelope is the load-bearing estimate of the exact triple-contact elimination displayed in Supplement B.1, with the signs of its second line and of the κ-free term of $\det H_P$ corrected as in Remark 3.8.)

Second, complete positive Fourier support of (1.1) implies strict covariance positivity for every linearly independent finite family of derivative-evaluation distributions. Compactness then gives uniform eigenvalue floors for the corrected pair pins joined to a fixed-distance remote value-gradient block. The endpoint determinant factor r^2, the remote value window of width $\kappa r^3/6$ and the Palm normalizer $Z_r \asymp r^2$ give

$$\mathbb{E}_r^{MS} N_{\text{far}} \le Cr^3\big[1+(|b|+\kappa)^{10}\big]e^{-c(b^2+\kappa^2)}. \tag{3.17}$$

Third, the local unstable-manifold comparison is performed in the correctly scaled transverse matrix

$$T_r = -\frac{Q_\perp}{\kappa r}. \tag{3.18}$$

The inward branch is captured by the maximum, and the outward branch crosses a forward section at a level strictly above $f(M)$; this is Theorem 3.6. Shallow-eigenvalue, finite-jet and fifth-derivative failures have Palm probability $O(r^3)$ or $o(r^3)$.

Theorem 3.6 (energy-adapted capture and escape; Supplement Theorem A.4.6)**.** *On a fixed compact convex chart, with $X \in \mathbb{R}$ along the pair and $Y \in \mathbb{R}^2$ across it, consider the normalized potential*

$$P(X,Y) = p_0(X) + \tfrac{1}{2}(X^2-\tfrac{1}{4})a\cdot Y - \tfrac{1}{2}Y^\top TY + \tfrac{1}{2}X\,Y^\top WY + \tfrac{1}{6}C[Y,Y,Y] + r\,Q(X,Y), \tag{3.18a}$$

with $p_0(X) = X^3/3 - X/4 - 1/12$, $T \succ 0$ and W symmetric, C a symmetric cubic tensor, and Q with $Q = 0$ and $\nabla Q = 0$ at $M = (-\frac{1}{2},0)$ and $S = (\frac{1}{2},0)$; for the conditioned side-24 field, $T = T_r$ of (3.18). Put $R = 1 + |a| + \|W\| + \|C\| + \|Q\|_{C^2}$ and $\tau = \lambda_{\min}(T)$, and fix $K = 4096$, $\varepsilon_0 = 1/(1024K)$. If $rR^5 \le \varepsilon_0$, $\tau \ge 2KR^5 + 2R$ and $r \le r_{\text{mat}}$, then:

- *(i) the M-ward unstable half-branch of S converges to M through the tapered tube $|Y| \le (2R/\tau)(\frac{1}{4} - X^2)$;*
- *(ii) the outward branch stays in an energy cone and strip and reaches $X = 5/4$ at a level greater than $49/192 - 1/768 = 65/256 > 1/4$, strictly above the level of M, so it cannot terminate at M;*
- *(iii) both conclusions hold for the exact conditioned field on the fifth-derivative good event.*

No bound on $\lambda_{\max}(T)$ is assumed or used. The four numerical margins of the proof are verified in exact rational arithmetic.

Proof of Corollary 3.5. By Lemma 3.4, selection failure produces a collar witness, a singular-near witness, a fixed-distance witness or a same-maximum self-attachment, and by the three estimates above and Theorem 3.6 each event has Palm probability $O(r^3)$. This proves (3.13) (Supplement Corollary A.2.2). For (3.13a): on an event of Palm probability at least cr^3 — the planar polygonal-path obstruction, embedded in the soft eigenplane of the pair with the remaining transverse directions hard — the component born at M is already connected to an older component at level $f(S)$, so the elder rule rejects the pair [R6]. □

By (3.12), the elder-selected lifetime density on any compact mark window therefore differs from the all-typed one by exactly $\Theta(\ell^{2/3})$. The leading constant $c_{3,24}$ is unaffected. The constants in (3.13)–(3.13a) are existential.

Remark 3.7 (the rejection mechanism). The mechanism of rejection is local and explicit: at scale r the pair sees a pinned planar cubic, and it is rejected exactly when that cubic carries an extra critical point at a height between $f(S)$ and $f(M)$, in which case M dies at the highest such saddle. The coefficient of the $\Theta(\ell^{2/3})$ selection loss is then a Gaussian integral of the corresponding local cluster mass [R10]; see also §5.3.

Remark 3.8 (signs in Supplement B.1). An independent exact elimination [R1] confirms the first displayed line of Supplement (B.1) and corrects two transcription slips: in the second line, for $-\det H_S$, the κ-linear bracket carries a minus sign,

$$-\det H_S = \frac{\kappa^2(4c^2-\eta^2)^2 - 4\kappa s^2\big((4c^2-\eta^2)q_M + (12c^2+\eta^2)q_S\big) + 4s^4(q_M-q_S)^2}{64c^2s^2},$$

and the κ-free term of $\det H_P$ is $-16c(q_M^2-q_S^2)s^4 + 4\eta(q_M-q_S)^2s^4$; both κ^2 coefficients equal $(4c^2-\eta^2)^2/(64c^2s^2)$. The load-bearing envelope (3.16) does not use these per-Hessian formulas and is unaffected.

3.5. **All-mark domination, the near/far decomposition and the limit.** The corrected pair target is uniformly injective in (b,κ). Gaussian regression and bounded conditional polynomial moments give the common majorant

$$C\big[1+(|b|+\kappa)^N\big]e^{-c(b^2+\kappa^2)}\,\kappa^{-2/3}, \tag{3.19}$$

which is integrable on $S^2\times\mathbb{R}\times(0,\infty)$. Since $0\le p_r\le 1$, (3.13) and dominated convergence show that the selected and all-typed contact integrals have the same limit.

Theorem 3.9 (limit interchange; Supplement Theorem A.3.3)**.** *Assume (H1) $G_r^{\mathrm{sel}}\to G_0^{\mathrm{sel}}$ pointwise as $r\downarrow 0$; (H2) one integrable majorant for $\kappa^{-2/3}G_r^{\mathrm{sel}}$, including $\kappa\downarrow 0$; (H3) $G_0^{\mathrm{sel}}=G_0^{\mathrm{all}}$. Then*

$$\nu_\varrho^{\mathrm{near}}(\ell) = c_{3,24}\,\ell^{-1/3}(1+o(1)), \qquad c_{3,24} = \frac{6^{2/3}}{18}\int \kappa^{-2/3}\,G_0^{\mathrm{all}}\,d\kappa\,db\,d\sigma_2(t).$$

All three hypotheses are verified in Supplement A.3; the majorant (3.19) *supplies (H2), and* (3.13) *with dominated convergence supplies (H3).*

Proposition 3.10 (far elder pairs; the bounded part of Supplement Proposition A.3.2)**.** *For fixed $\varrho\in(0,12)$ there is $\ell_0>0$ such that $\sup_{0<\ell\le\ell_0}\nu_\varrho^{\mathrm{far}}(\ell)<\infty$. In particular $\nu_\varrho^{\mathrm{far}}(\ell)=o(\ell^{-1/3})$.*

Proof. This is the bound (14.1) of [R2]. □

Theorem 3.9 and Proposition 3.10 give the leading term of (2.1). Independently, the far elder contribution tends to zero as $\ell\downarrow 0$ [R7]. Two rates are on record [R9]: $O(\ell^{2/3})$, because a bar of lifetime ℓ is born at a maximum of weakest curvature $O(\ell^{1/3})$ (reviewed and merged); and $O(\ell^N)$ for every N, because on the superlevel component of a living bar the gradient is $O((K(b-f))^{1/2})$, so that a far death forces N separated near-critical sites (one provider's nonauthor review). A reviewed quantitative extension allows the separation to shrink like a small power of ℓ [R9]. The bound $O(\ell)$ asserted for the far density in the amendment of 1 August 2026 (Supplement Proposition A.3.2) is withdrawn: its proof bounded the far *candidate* density, which does not vanish (Remark 2.5).

3.6. **Exact coefficient reduction.** Even and odd covariance derivatives are independent because K_{24} is even. Integrating over the birth height removes the field-value coordinate:

$$\int_{\mathbb{R}} p_{(f,h_t)}(b,0)\,\mathbb{E}\big[F(q_t)\mid f=b,\ h_t=0\big]\,db = p_{h_t}(0)\,\mathbb{E}\big[F(q_t)\mid h_t=0\big], \tag{3.20}$$

where $F(q)=(\det Q_t(q))^2\mathbf{1}_{\{Q_t(q)<0\}}$. Conditionally on $g_t=0$, the variable u_t is centered Gaussian with variance σ_t^2. The remaining normalized-gap integral is

$$\int_0^\infty p_{(u_t,g_t)}(-\kappa/6,0)\,\kappa^{4/3}\,d\kappa = p_{g_t}(0)\,\frac{\Gamma(7/6)\,72^{7/6}\,(\sigma_t^2)^{2/3}}{2\sqrt{2\pi}}. \tag{3.21}$$

Combining (3.10), (3.12), (3.20) and (3.21) gives exactly (2.9).

Equivalently, if $A_tA_t^\top=\Gamma_t$ and $\mathcal{Q}_t(v)=Q_t(A_tv)$, then

$$D_t=\frac{15}{4\pi}\int_{S^2}[\det\mathcal{Q}_t(v)]^2\,\mathbf{1}_{\{\operatorname{tr}\mathcal{Q}_t(v)<0,\ \det\mathcal{Q}_t(v)>0\}}\,dv. \tag{3.22}$$

Thus $c_{3,24}$ is a deterministic nested angular integral involving only the order-six covariance jet at the origin.

3.7. **The value on $\mathbb{R}^3$.** At the jet of the (non-periodized) Bargmann–Fock covariance $e^{-|z|^2/2}$,

$$\Sigma_g=I_3,\qquad \Sigma_h=\operatorname{diag}(3,1,1),\qquad \sigma_t^2=\frac{1}{24}, \tag{3.23}$$

and

$$Q\mid h_t=0\ \overset{d}{=}\ G_2+\sqrt{\tfrac{2}{3}}\,Z\,I_2,\qquad D_t=\frac{29}{6}-\sqrt{6}, \tag{3.24}$$

where G_2 is a standard 2×2 GOE matrix and $Z\sim N(0,1)$ is independent. The value of D_t is proved in closed form in Supplement B.2′: in trace and difference coordinates $T\sim N(0,4)$ is independent of $D\ge0$, $\det Q=(W^2-D^2)/4$, and the cone condition is $W<-D$ for the single Gaussian $W=T+2\sqrt{2/3}\,Z\sim N(0,20/3)$. Substitution in (2.9) gives (2.11).

3.8. **Side-24 correction.** Let J_0 be the even covariance jet of $e^{-|z|^2/2}$ through order six, J_{24} the corresponding jet of (1.1), and

$$F(J)=\frac{\Phi(J)}{\Phi(J_0)}, \tag{3.25}$$

where Φ is the coefficient functional in (2.9). On the explicit jet ball

$$\|J-J_0\|_{\max}\le 10^{-110}, \tag{3.26}$$

the covariance and Schur-complement matrices have uniform positive lower and finite upper bounds. Fixed-cone Gaussian differentiation gives

$$\sup\|DF\|<10^{16},\qquad \sup\|D^2F\|<10^{42}. \tag{3.27}$$

Put $q=e^{-288}$. The normalized periodized jet has the decomposition

$$J_{24}-J_0=J_{\mathrm{near}}^{(1)}+R_{\mathrm{jet}}, \tag{3.28}$$

where the linear term comes from the six images $\pm24e_i$, and exact rational Hermite bounds give

$$\|J_{24}-J_0\|_{\max}<10^{-113},\qquad \|R_{\mathrm{jet}}\|_{\max}<10^{-230}. \tag{3.29}$$

Rotational projection of the six-image orbit yields

$$DF(J_0)\big[J_{\mathrm{near}}^{(1)}\big]=P_3(24)\,e^{-288}, \tag{3.30}$$

where

$$P_3(L)=-\frac{L^2(10L^4-147L^2+315)}{105},\qquad P_3(24)=-\frac{620813376}{35}. \tag{3.31}$$

The first variation (3.30) is derived from first principles in Supplement B.2. In the jet coordinates a, m_4, χ, Ω of the technical appendix (Module H), the variations $\delta a = -2L^2$, $\delta m_4 = 6L^4/5 - 12L^2$ and $\delta\chi = -6L^6/7 + 18L^4 - 90L^2$ and the display $\delta \log c = \delta\Omega/9 + \delta m_4/6 - \frac{13}{6}\delta a = P_3(L)$ follow from kernel differentiation of the periodized kernel and Haar projection, with the pure partials $\partial_a = \partial_{m_4} = -1/2$, $\partial_\chi = 1/9$ taken through the full nonlinear functional (including the homogeneity term of $D(\Gamma)$), and the scale check $d \log c / d \log \lambda = 3/2$; the regrouped display is an algebraic identity via $\delta\Omega = \chi\,\delta a + a\,\delta\chi - 2m_4\,\delta m_4$. Both $P_3(24) = -620813376/35$ and the first variation are also derived independently in [R4]. Taylor's theorem, (3.27) and (3.29) give

$$|DF(J_0)[R_{\mathrm{jet}}]| < 10^{-210}, \qquad |R_{\mathrm{quad}}| < 5 \cdot 10^{-185}, \tag{3.32}$$

and therefore

$$F(J_{24}) - 1 = P_3(24)\, e^{-288} + \varepsilon_{24}, \qquad |\varepsilon_{24}| < 10^{-180}. \tag{3.33}$$

The second-order remainder admits two sharper and independent bounds [R4]. (i) A second-order Taylor expansion of the coefficient functional along the periodization perturbation, using the Gaussian-section representation $c = 96^{-1/3} \int_{S^2} F(C_u)\, d\sigma(u)$ and an exact Haar first order, gives $|\varepsilon_{24}| < 10^{-218}$, with a remainder ledger below $6 \cdot 10^{-235}$. (ii) A derivation with exact χ^2_ν radial moments gives $|\varepsilon_{24}| < 10^{-216}$ for $d = 2, 3$, and identifies the general polynomial

$$P_d(L) = -\frac{10L^6}{3(d+2)(d+4)} + \frac{(d+4)L^4}{d+2} - dL^2,$$

which reduces to P_3 at $d = 3$. Either bound gives (2.10); we state the weaker one. This completes the proof of the leading term of Theorem 2.1 and of (2.10).

Remark 3.11 (torus and reference contact coefficients). The near-contact quantities themselves move very little under periodization. On the torus of side $L = 24$, for birth heights in $[0, 1]$ and gaps in $[1/2, 2]$, the $d = 3$ near-contact numerators and normalizer differ from their reference-kernel values by less than 10^{-26}, and the compact-band contact integral differs by less than 10^{-19} in absolute value [R20].

3.9. **The rate.**

Proposition 3.12 (bounded remainder)**.** *There are $C, \ell_* > 0$ such that $|\nu_{3,24}(\ell) - c_{3,24}\ell^{-1/3}| \le C$ for $0 < \ell \le \ell_*$.*

Proof. This is Theorem R of [R3] at $d = 3$ and $L = 24$; Theorem R holds for every fixed $d \ge 2$ and $L > 0$, for all marks and separations, with existential constants. □

Proposition 3.12 is the rate in (2.1). In Theorem R the near cutoff region and the far candidate pairs each contribute $O(1)$. That whole bounded term is rejected mass, so for elder pairs it tends to zero, and Theorem 2.3 identifies the next terms. □

4. Exact scope

Theorem 2.1 is restricted to:

- ambient dimension 3;
- torus side 24;
- the normalized periodized Bargmann–Fock covariance (1.1);
- finite nonessential superlevel H_0 bars;
- the first-moment lifetime density as $\ell \downarrow 0$;
- the ordered maximum–index-two-saddle, directed-S^2 and Palm conventions used above.

It does not imply:

- a theorem for other side lengths;

- a theorem for arbitrary isotropic or stationary Gaussian fields;
- a result for H_k, $k > 0$;
- an interchange of the limits $L \to \infty$ and $\ell \downarrow 0$;
- an infinite-volume persistence process;
- an explicit range of ℓ on which (2.1) or (2.12) holds to a stated accuracy: every remainder constant in this paper is existential;
- a numerical value of ε_{24}, or a directed-rounding certificate for the nonlinear integral (2.9) beyond the enclosure of $c_{3,\infty}$ to 10^{-106} [R5]. Such a certificate is not used in the analytic estimate (2.10).

The records behind Theorem 2.3 and Remarks 2.4–2.5 hold in the dimensions and sides stated in each record, at their stated scopes, and the numerical enclosures are specific to the sides stated. This paper states them only for $d = 3$ and $L = 24$.

5. Discussion

Statements in this section are labelled *proved* (a merged record with nonauthor review), *read* (read in bounded nonauthor slices from the same account), *author-side*, *numerical* (computation or simulation without certification) or *expectation* (not proved); conditional scopes are stated in place. None is used in §3.

5.1. **Why $-1/3$, and what depends on the law.** In the separation variable $r = |M - S|$, the ordered maximum/saddle pair measure is the polar volume r^{d-1} times the two-site pin density, of order $r^{-(d+3)}$, times the determinant scale r^2; that is, $r^{-2}\,dr$ in every dimension, while the height gap of a pinned pair is $\ell = kr^3$. Substituting $r = (\ell/k)^{1/3}$ gives $\ell^{-1/3}$ with no dependence on d; the corresponding theorem of [R2] (Theorem C) holds for every $d \geq 2$, and the present $d = 3$, side-24 statement is one instance. The exponent is the Whitney-fold exponent: in a one-parameter family a maximum/saddle pair annihilates through $f_t(x) = x^3/3 - (t_0 - t)x$, with separation proportional to $(t_0 - t)^{1/2}$ and gap proportional to $(t_0 - t)^{3/2}$, so the time spent with gap in $d\ell$ is proportional to $\ell^{-1/3}\,d\ell$. The Gaussian law enters only the constant: by [R2], (15.2), $c_{d,L}$ is an angular average of $p_G(0)\,p_{V_u}(0)\,\tau_u^{4/3} D_u$, that is, of densities and of a cone moment of the 3-jet at the collision point, and it scales as $a^{-2/3}$ under $f \mapsto af$. The proof separates accordingly: the elder rule near a collision (the cap theorem), the barrier $\lambda_{\min}(-D^2 f(M)) \leq (\ell K^2/c_L)^{1/3}$ for a bar of lifetime ℓ, and the pinned-pair identities are deterministic statements about C^3 functions; the Gaussian structure supplies the regression couplings and the uniform moment and density bounds. We therefore expect, but do not prove, that the exponent is shared by stationary fields with C^7 paths, finite moments of the derivative suprema and a continuous positive density of the 3-jet at a point, with c given by the analogue of (15.2) of [R2] (*expectation*).

The near-diagonal law has a second scale. The leading term comes from separations $r \asymp \ell^{1/3}$; at $r \asymp \ell^{1/4}$ the cubic coefficient is comparable to the separation ($\ell \asymp r^4$, the cusp organizing the fold family), and there the first correction arises: on that scale the pinned landscape is a universal quartic ridge on which a maximum/saddle pair of the right types is an elder pair in only one third of its type window, so the local contact law overcounts and the correction $c_1\ell^{1/4}$ of Theorem 2.3 is negative.

5.2. **The corrections.** At separations $r \asymp \ell^{1/4}$ the rescaled pinned landscape converges to a universal random quartic whose superlevel topology reduces exactly to the one-dimensional ridge

$$g = \kappa[2(X + \tfrac{1}{2})^2(X - 1) + 3\varphi(X^2 - \tfrac{1}{4})^2];$$

the pair is typed if and only if $|\varphi| < 1$, and the saddle is the maximum's elder partner if and only if $|\varphi| < 1/3$ (at $\varphi = \pm 1/3$ two competing saddles, respectively maxima, have equal heights). Integrating the resulting loss over the scale gives (2.13) (*proved*, [R11]). The elder rule enters

the expansion only through this cusp scale. There the decision is stable with an explicit margin proportional to $\big||\varphi| - 1/3\big|$; at the fold scale and at larger separations the elder rule costs a power of ℓ beyond $\ell^{1/3}$. So the third coefficient of the elder law is the same fold-scale constant c_2 as for the candidate law (*proved*, [R11]).

At large $\kappa = \ell/r^4$ the rejected pairs are soft: exactly one transverse curvature is small, of order γ_1^2/κ, and the rejected cusp kernel decays like F_0/κ in every dimension; for the Gaussian kernel in $d = 3$, $\iint F_0 = 125\sqrt{30}/(192\pi^3) \approx 0.1150$ (*proved*, [R15]). The fold-scale rejection rate is the selection-loss coefficient of Remark 3.7; for the Gaussian kernel it equals $F_0 H(k)$ with $H(k) = 1 + \frac{12}{25}k^2 + h_{7/2}k^{7/2} + O(k^4)$ and an explicit $h_{7/2} < 0$ (*proved* at the conditional scope of [R15], Theorem B). These soft rejected pairs produce the $\ell^{2/3}$ term $R_{2/3}$ of the rejected density in Remark 2.4; in a full-field simulation in $d = 3$, rejected adjacent pairs with $r/\ell^{1/4} < 0.8$ number 11, against 10.7 predicted and 1,329 from the cusp kernel alone (*numerical*, [R16, R15]).

Size of the corrections. By (2.14), the total relative correction of the three-term law is about -1.5% at $\ell = 10^{-4}$, -5% at 10^{-3} and -17% at 10^{-2}; the two corrections partially cancel. A direct simulation of the elder-rule persistence of the periodized Gaussian field (sides 64 in $d = 2$ and 16 in $d = 3$), with exact critical values and exact one-dimensional connectivity by ascending lines, agrees with the three-term law over $10^{-4} \le \ell \le 10^{-2}$ (data over law 1.006 ± 0.004 in $d = 2$ and 1.008 ± 0.010 in $d = 3$) and rejects the leading and two-term laws; it also shows the cusp-scale elder window $|\varphi| < 1/3$ directly. Adding the $\ell^{2/3}$ term of Remark 2.4 improves the fit further (χ^2 from 84 to 23 in $d = 3$ and from 44 to 7 in $d = 2$, over 14 bins on $[10^{-4}, 3 \cdot 10^{-2}]$), leaving a small negative next-order term (*numerical*, [R16]). The simulation illustrates the law; it does not prove it, and its residuals are not evidence for an $\ell^{1/2}$ term.

5.3. **Selection loss in dimension three.** In $d \ge 3$ the hard transverse directions do not change the local decision: maximizing over the hard fibre reduces the decision window to the planar model up to an error of order r in C^2, so the planar elder/rejected certificate transfers to the actual field with margins of the same order (*author-side*: addenda A3 and A3.1 with their erratum, read in bounded nonauthor slices, [R18]). On compact marks the exhaustion has been carried out in $d = 3$: the failure-measure rate holds at every $\beta < 1$, with

$$1 - p_r = r^3 \alpha^{(3)} + O(r^4 \log(1/r)^7),$$

where $\alpha^{(3)}$ is the local cluster mass of Remark 3.7, identified with the fold-scale coefficient $F/(kA_0)$ of [R10]. As a corollary, on compact windows of births and gaps the rejected density is $C^{(3)}_{\mathrm{fail}} \ell^{2/3} + O(\ell \log(1/\ell)^7)$, with $C^{(3)}_{\mathrm{fail}} = \int A_0 \, \alpha^{(3)}/(3k^{5/3}) \, db \, dk \, d\sigma(u)$ over the window and A_0 the pinned-pair weight of [R10] (*read*, and conditional on the author-side chain A3.3–A3.8; independence credit 0; [R18]). All constants are existential, and no rate of this type is claimed for the unrestricted population.

5.4. **Dimension one.** In dimension one every ingredient of the short-bar expansion can be made explicit. For a smooth stationary Gaussian process on a circle, and on the line under a mild spectral hypothesis, the persistence lifetime density satisfies

$$\nu(\ell) = C_0 \ell^{-1/3} + C_1 \ell^{1/4} + 2B_2 \ell^{1/3} + O(\ell^{3/4}),$$

with $C_1 < 0$ and B_2 explicit in the spectral moments; $B_2 > 0$ when $\lambda_2 \lambda_6 \le 25\lambda_4^2$, for instance for the Gaussian kernel, but its sign is not fixed in general (*proved* on the circle, Theorems 1D and 1D$^+$; on the line *author-side*, read by four nonauthor slices and merged; [R17]). The coefficient C_1 is the one-dimensional value of the cusp formula (2.13), the elder window of the cusp ridge is the same $|\varphi| < 1/3$, and the remainder is of the order of the first correction to the cusp term. For the covariance $e^{-x^2/2}$ the crest-to-trough amplitude density per crest is $0.19971814\, h^{-1/3} - 0.27165891\, h^{1/4} + 0.41725471\, h^{1/3} + O(h^{3/4})$. A simulation over $8 \cdot 10^7$ correlation

lengths reproduces the three-term law to 0.3% and the coefficient of the rejected pairs to 1% (*numerical*). For the Gaussian kernel the second- and third-order terms of the lifetime density nearly cancel for $10^{-4} \le \ell \le 10^{-2}$ (relative coefficients $C_1/C_0 = -2.07$ and $2B_2/C_0 = +2.09$), a caution against reading corrections off histograms at moderate ℓ.

5.5. **The plane.** In dimension two the local pairing rule is established for the actual Gaussian field with a rate. On the bounded soft layer, the H_0 pairing of the designated pin pair agrees with the model's elder decision except on a set of weighted probability $O(r^{7/2})$, against a layer mass of order r^3 (*proved*, [R19]). On compact gap intervals the selection loss satisfies $1 - p_r = r^3(\alpha_1 + \alpha_2) + O(r^4 \log(1/r)^4)$, so that on compact windows of births and gaps the rejected density is $C_{\mathrm{fail}}\ell^{2/3} + O(\ell \log(1/\ell)^4)$ (*read*, and conditional on C103, A4.1 and A4.2; independence credit 0; [R19]). These are statements about $d = 2$; Theorem 2.1 is a $d = 3$ statement.

6. Literature position

The closest located literature falls into four groups.

Persistent homology of random fields. Adler–Bobrowski–Borman–Subag–Weinberger [1] and Pranav [19] study persistent homology of random and Gaussian fields, principally through general structure and computation; Bobrowski–Borman [5] compute expected barcode descriptors of Gaussian fields (alternating sums of bar lengths over homological degrees), which integrate lifetimes rather than resolving the H_0 lifetime measure near zero. Feldbrugge, van Engelen, van de Weygaert, Pranav and Vegter [9] express expected two-dimensional superlevel persistence diagrams through candidate maximum–saddle densities and the probability that the saddle kills the component born at the given maximum: this is the selection-kernel architecture of §3, without a short-gap asymptotic. Chazal–Divol [7] prove absolute continuity of expected persistence diagrams for random point-cloud filtrations and treat Brownian sublevel sets; their results justify the existence of such densities in those settings and do not assert a general near-diagonal rate for smooth stationary Gaussian fields.

Critical points of Gaussian fields. Klein–Agam [12] describe the short-distance correlation of critical points, of order r^{2-d}, and Azaïs–Delmas [4] prove it, with explicit constants, for critical points of adjacent indices; in polar coordinates this is the $r\,dr$ pair measure behind (3.10). Ladgham–Lachièze-Rey [13] prove local repulsion of planar critical points, and Ancona–Gass–Letendre–Stecconi [3] analyze Kac–Rice singularities and cumulants. None of these imposes a height gap or the elder pairing, and the cubic fold exponent itself is classical.

Limit theorems for topological functionals and short features. Hirsch–Lachièze-Rey [10] prove functional central limit theorems for topological functionals of Gaussian fields on growing domains. Chenavier–Hirsch [8] prove Poisson limits for persistent cycles of random point clouds with extremal (minimal and maximal) lifetimes, and Hirsch–Lundbye–Otto [11] for large-lifetime cycles, including on the torus. Perez [18] obtains small-cutoff asymptotics of bar counts for continuous semimartingales, governed by quadratic variation; that concerns rough paths and counts above a cutoff, a different regularity class.

Dimension one. Rice [20] and Cartwright–Longuet-Higgins [6] studied the heights of the maxima of a stationary Gaussian process, the latter also crest-to-trough heights for narrow spectra. The amplitude between a local maximum and the next minimum was studied by Lindgren [15], using Slepian-model conditional formulas, and by Lindgren–Rychlik [17]; Lindgren [14] shows that near a maximum of very low height the process is a random quartic, a low-level regime rather than a small-amplitude law. The exact joint law of adjacent extremes [16] contains the small-amplitude behaviour of §5.4 implicitly, but we have not found the $-1/3$ law stated there.

We have not located, in these sources or in the indexed and web searches recorded in [R21] (the latest on 13 October 2026), a prior theorem giving the fixed-side three-dimensional near-diagonal

H_0 density (2.1), the coefficient reduction (2.9) or the correction (2.10), nor any near-diagonal lifetime law for the H_0 persistence of smooth Gaussian fields in dimension at least two. Substantial constituent mechanisms — the fold, the close-pair correlation, the selection kernel — are prior art. This is evidence of novelty, not a substitute for a systematic MathSciNet and zbMATH search with backward and forward citation chasing, which remains to be done before submission.

7. Verification record and disclosure

Human review. No independent human specialist has reviewed this work.

AI review. All independent verification of the proof chain to date was carried out by AI systems — models of Anthropic, OpenAI and xAI, and Grok Bot support agents (Cursor-hosted, distinct from the xAI model lane) — posting from a single repository account under the author's direction. Every review record cites the exact file bytes it reviewed. No organizational independence is claimed for any review. In that sense: the leading term of Theorem 2.1 rests on the July/August 2026 proof (§3 and [R1]) and on a parent chain with provider-distinct AI reviews [R2]; the rate in (2.1) and the bound (2.10) each have nonauthor reviews from two providers [R3, R4]; the lower bound (3.13a) has one provider's nonauthor review [R6]; the records behind Remark 3.7 have reads from two providers [R10], as does Remark 3.11 at its contact-integral scope [R20]; every link of Theorem 2.3 has an OpenAI/Codex nonauthor review and an additional nonauthor read by Grok Bot agents [R11, R12]; the results of Remark 2.4, and the $c_3\ell^{2/3}$ term and the rate δ in Remark 2.5, were read in bounded nonauthor slices [R14], while the rest of Remark 2.5 rests on records with one or two providers' nonauthor reviews [R7, R13]; and the Discussion labels its own items.

Computer assistance. The enclosures in Theorem 2.3(iii) and Remark 2.4(c) use outward-rounded interval arithmetic in the Python standard library, with replayable controls and rejected mutants in the cited records. The exact triple-contact elimination (Supplement B.1), the closed form of D_t in (3.24) and the margins of Theorem 3.6 were computed in exact arithmetic with SymPy and Python fractions; the elimination was re-checked independently in exact standard-library arithmetic (Remark 3.8), and $c_{3,\infty}$ is enclosed independently [R5].

Remaining before submission. The MathSciNet/zbMATH pass of §6; conversion of the technical appendix and of the records of Theorem 2.3 into conventionally numbered supplementary lemmas and proofs, without provenance labels; and a journal-specific notation, bibliography and style pass. A finite-ℓ error band for (2.1) is not available (§4).

Appendix A. Repository records

The supplementary records cited as [Rn] are the following. Paths are in the repository `https://github.com/d6g8k5htny-coder/Math-` at the head of its `main` branch on 13 October 2026 (commit `b68d88b3`); "PR n" is the pull request that landed the record, with its merge commit, and hexadecimal prefixes after a path are Git blob identifiers. Review records are linked from each pull request.

[R1] *Technical appendix and supplement.* SIDE24 technical appendix, V2 edition (Modules B–K, 1 August 2026), and `SIDE24_GAP_FILL_SUPPLEMENT.md` (Parts A–E, 1 August 2026; 48,972 bytes), in the author's pre-review package. Independent exact re-elimination of Supplement B.1: `reviews_side24_b1_display_claude_20260930/` (author's archive).

[R2] *Parent theorem.* `imports/lifetime_parent_20260925/UNIFORM_MATRIX_CAP_AND_LIFETIME.md` (`dfed3b8d`); Theorems A and C, (14.1), (15.2). Full-depth nonauthor review of D1-C/D/E: PR 143 (`3216e2e7`).

[R3] *Theorem R.* `frontiers/three_fronts_20260924/LIFETIME_REMAINDER.md` (`247b3ecf`). Reviews: xAI, slices R1–R6 (`main` PR 67); Anthropic, full depth, PR 186 (`c839f286`).

[R4] *The correction (2.10).* `coefficients/side24_remainder_20260929/PROOF.md` (`0bcf0a6f`; PR 154, `8e61fc4c`); `frontiers/side24_periodization_remainder_20260929/PROOF.md` (`03291568`; PR 156, `8ba851fb`); first variation: `frontiers/side24_periodization_20260929/PROOF.md` (`1a84f215`; PR 144, `0cd0b821`).

[R5] *Coefficient enclosure.* `coefficients/side24_v1` (enclosure of $c_{3,\infty}$ to 10^{-106}), with the independent recomputation `reviews/side24_v1_coefficient_claude_20260929`.

[R6] *Lower bound (3.13a).* `frontiers/window_multiplicity_laws_20260928/ELDER_LOWER_AND_DENSITY_GAP.md` (`aaefc8da`); `frontiers/elder_dimension_lift_20260928/PROOF.md` (`7303bd79`); `frontiers/elder_lower_all_d_20260929/PROOF.md` (`7f41c9e3`; PR 149, `21244e5e`; Theorem E1$_d$).

[R7] *Unrestricted marks.* Theorem U: `frontiers/unrestricted_selection_difference_20260929/PROOF.md` (`5a55b179`); Theorem K and Corollary T: `frontiers/c7_total_bounded_20260929/PROOF.md` (`28748b08`; PR 150, `7f438fca`), with `ERRATUM_NORMALIZED_FORM.md` (PR 289, `5b012335`); Theorem Z: `frontiers/c7_zero_gap_limit_20260929/PROOF.md` (`5b6328ea`; PR 155, `7a1cb09a`).

[R8] *Equal-height mass.* `frontiers/equal_height_mass_value_20261001/` (PR 211, `94f9e75e`): Proposition V (volume law); γ_3 and $B_{3,24}$ are exploration.

[R9] *Far elder pairs.* `frontiers/far_elder_rate_20260930` (PR 187, `c2f1270d`; rate $O(\ell^{2/3})$); `frontiers/far_elder_flat_ridge_20260930` (PR 188, `f7f083ec`; Theorem G, rate $O(\ell^N)$, with the moving-cutoff extension C89).

[R10] *Rejection mechanism and coefficient.* `frontiers/local_elder_geometry_20260930` and companions (PR 170, `fa2e9909`; Theorems E and S); `frontiers/concave_fibre_elder_20260930` (PR 175, `eb659bd3`; Theorem F); `frontiers/local_pairing_20260930` (PR 180, `4522be59`); `frontiers/soft_fold_limit_20261002` (PR 243, `fa8b0d21`).

[R11] *The three-term law.* Theorem R$^+$: `frontiers/remainder_vanishing_20260930` (PR 191, `95565474`; errata PR 270, `ced1fca9`); Theorem R^{++}: `frontiers/remainder_rate_20260930` (PR 198, `124c37d9`); Theorems CU and CU$'$: `frontiers/cusp_second_order_20261001` (PR 207, `566b1a14`); Theorem T: `frontiers/candidate_third_order_20261001` (PR 218, `fb6ee97b`); Theorem E3: `frontiers/elder_third_order_20261001` (PR 220, `0d797780`); Theorems T$^+$ and E3$^+$: `frontiers/third_order_rate_20261001` (PR 229, `6f74f7a7`); the third coefficient: `frontiers/third_order_coefficient_20261001` (PR 216, `b718f235`).

[R12] *Certified constants.* c_1: `frontiers/cusp_coefficient_certified_20261001` (PR 219, `5a836a8e`); c_2 in closed form: `frontiers/c2_exact_20261001` (PR 223, `f9ebba17`); torus transfer of c_2: `frontiers/c2_finite_jet_transfer_20261001` (PR 232, `7fe06b01`).

[R13] *Theorem P.* `frontiers/candidate_parity_rate_20261001` (PR 237, `cb73b117`).

[R14] *The order $\ell^{2/3}$.* Notes TL: `frontiers/tl_soft_layer_20261006` (PR 384, `f3318db6`); TS: `frontiers/ts_small_kappa_20261006` (PR 387, `40440ed8`); EM: `frontiers/em_intermediate_elder_20261006` (PR 388, `ebbf3b7f`); EM.1, LU, C3 and SL: `frontiers/lifetime_two_thirds_chain_20261007` (PR 390, `7d2f6250`); C7: `frontiers/c7_elder_two_thirds_20261007` (PR 392, `7def48d4`); V24 and DC: `frontiers/v24_dc_two_thirds_sign_20261007` (PR 393, `73734950`); CJ: `frontiers/lifetime_cj_model_j_20261012` (PR 442, `ea2f3e25`); DD: `frontiers/lifetime_dd_model_d_20261013` (PR 450, `a115feeb`); C3-R: `frontiers/lifetime_c3r_rate_20261013` (PR 452, `dbe6c0a1`).

[R15] *Soft rejected pairs.* `frontiers/soft_rejected_pairs_20261002` (PR 242, `54c6759e`); the soft model in closed form, Theorems A and B: `frontiers/soft_closed_form_20261002` (PR 244, `07320089`), conditional on PR 170 Theorem E(1) and its cubic-model input.

[R16] *Simulation.* The full-field Monte Carlo records of PR 216 (`b718f235`) and the four-term comparison recorded with note V24.

[R17] *Dimension one.* Theorem 1D: `frontiers/d1_third_order_law_20261001` (PR 214, `e4ca2b3f`); Theorem 1D$^+$: `frontiers/d1_sharp_remainder_20261001` (PR 238, `8404169d`); on the line: `frontiers/d1_line_20261004` (PR 271, `4242ab95`, with its wording successor PR 286).

[R18] *Dimension three, compact marks.* `frontiers/qs_d3_soft_layer_chain_20261005` (PR 359, `298b2631`), storing the addenda A3–A3.11 and their reads; the hard-fibre reduction is A3 and A3.1 with their erratum, and the rate rests on the author-side chain A3.3–A3.8.

[R19] *The plane.* `frontiers/planar_soft_layer_chain_20261003` (PR 249, `e0bed3ed`); `frontiers/planar_compact_k_chain_20261006` (PR 360, `930bd976`).

[R20] *Torus contact coefficients.* Record C104 (`main` issue 229, comment 5967953399) and its reviews (comments 5968193256 and 5971201678, the latter with the constants evaluated).

[R21] *Literature searches.* `reviews/literature_lifetime_law_recon_20260929/RECONNAISSANCE.md` (`003b9879`; PR 147); `reviews/literature_classical_neighbors_20261001` (PR 210, `0cdc19fc`), including an indexed-database pass of 4 October 2026; two independent web searches of 13 October 2026 (`main` issue 275, comment 6146291432).

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